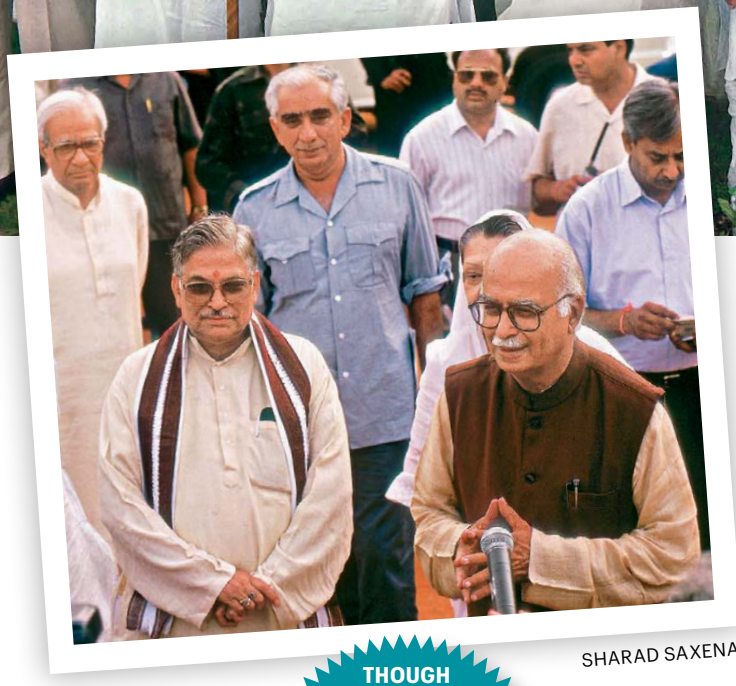


PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

SUPPORTING CAST

United Front leaders Pawar, Naidu, Lalu and others line up; the BJP's L.K. Advani and Co. bide their time

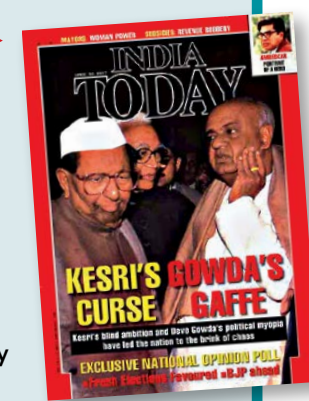


SHARAD SAXENA

THOUGH RARELY GIVEN CREDIT, THE UNITED FRONT FOUND A WAY FOR INDIA'S PLURALITY TO BE REPRESENTED MORE FULLY IN NEW DELHI

of a monolith: a congeries of old socialists, Mandal prizefighters like Mulayam and Lalu Yadav, regional satraps, Left ideologues. But the third run of non-Congressism added a vital new element to New Delhi politics: though rarely given credit, the United Front had found a way for the federal polity to be represented more fully. Unlike the older Janata test runs, they realised the challenges of cohering together, refined the coalition mechanism, and laid down a protocol that enabled ideologically disparate parties to cohabit honourably under a common minimum programme. They saw it as an asset, not a liability—a face of India's diversity. Federalism was no accidental byproduct of expediency: India was fulfilling its being as a Union of States, strong provinces staying loyal to their ecologies, rather than bowing to an imperial dominion. ■

Kesri's Curse, Gowda's Gaffe
Apr. 30, 1997



"On March 30, the last day of Lent, Congress president Sitaram Kesri thought he should resurrect his 112-year-old party, nailed firmly to the cross by popular rejection in three successive general elections. Twelve days later, when Kesri's long-winded letter of withdrawal of support to the United Front government pulled the plug on the H.D. Deve Gowda government, the Congress had in no way risen from the dead. In fact, it was more dead than before. Besides, the field was strewn with many more corpses, notably that of the 10-month-old UF government, headed by a bumbling prime minister who had all along been living on borrowed time but would not make an effort to pre-empt the looming crisis."